DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

4.5 Declarations of Freedom

Beginning in the late-1600s, political thinkers put forth new ideas about natural rights and human equality in books, articles, essays, and pamphlets. These writings set the stage for a revolution that created a nation and transformed the world.

This painting by John Trumbull, titled *Declaration of Independence,* depicts the moment on June 28, 1776, when the first draft of the document was presented to the Second Continental Congress in the Pennsylvania State House. In the painting, Thomas Jefferson, thought to be the main author of the document, places the document in front of John Hancock, who was the president of the Congress, surrounded by members of the committee who helped create the draft.

CRITICAL VIEWING What do you notice about the people who are gathered for the presentation of the first draft of the Declaration of Independence?



U.S. Capitol Rotunda, Washington, D.C.

Declaration of Independence, John Trumbull, 1817

This is the first of four Revolutionary-era scenes that the U.S. Congress commissioned from John Trumbull. The artist had created a smaller version of this painting to document the events of the American Revolution, and he enlarged the painting for the Rotunda between August 1817 and September 1818. It was installed in the Rotunda in 1826, along with three other Trumbull paintings.

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DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Legal Document
from the Declaration of Independence, 1776

The Declaration of Independence begins with a clear statement of its writers' beliefs. The goal of the Declaration was to unify the colonies as one new nation in opposition to Great Britain.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE In what ways is this vision of governing different from how the British monarchy governed?

> We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness. That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government.

DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Legal Document
from the Declaration of Independence, 1776

The second part of the Declaration contains a long list of offenses by the king against the colonies. In total, Jefferson included 27 grievances that referred to the Quartering Act, the Intolerable Acts, and several other British attempts to impose their will on the colonies.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE Why do you think the writers included such a complete list of grievances against the king?

> To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.
>
> He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.
>
> He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people.
>
> He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures.

DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Essay
from *Two Treatises on Government,* by John Locke, 1689

Nearly a century before the American Revolution, John Locke outlined his theories of government in two treatises, or essays. In the second treatise, he explained his thoughts on liberty and the consent of people to be governed. Thomas Jefferson drew heavily on Locke's political theories when creating the Declaration.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE In what ways did Locke's ideas directly influence the actions of the colonies and the writing of the Declaration of Independence?

> Men being . . . by nature, all free, equal, and independent, no one can be put out of this estate, and subjected to the political power of another, without his own consent. The only way . . . any one divests himself of his natural liberty, and puts on the bonds of civil society, is by agreeing with other men to join and unite into a community, for their comfortable, safe and peaceable living one amongst another.

Read the full Declaration of Independence in the Citizenship Handbook.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about the events leading up to the Declaration of Independence.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main ideas about government expressed in the Declaration of Independence and Locke's *Second Treatise on Government.*
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: How did beliefs about the nature of government and human freedom lead to the colonies' break with Britain?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write an informative paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.

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